Module 6: Effective Communication and Stakeholder Management

Detailed supplement: the deck topics the handbook module extends, with worked examples, a rewrite exercise and an assignment

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MODULE 6 · HOW TO USE THIS SUPPLEMENT

Coverage map: what is new and what is already in the module

Read this supplement next to the main Module 6 handbook. **Extended** means the handbook has the topic and this PDF adds the deck's example or template. **New** means the handbook did not have it. Examples with numbers are hypothetical, as the deck labels them.

Topic	Handbook section	Status here
Answer first: Pyramid Principle and SCQA	6.2	Extended: one full worked example from a checkout problem
Storytelling with data	6.3	Extended: title = takeaway; chart choice rules
Communication map: idea to general availability	—	New: the product stage map and what to write at each stage
Layers of communication	—	New: immediate team, stakeholders, upward, outer circle
Power–interest stakeholder map	6.4	Extended: how to re-map as the project changes
RACI and DACI	6.5	Extended: a worked role table for one decision
Influence without authority	6.4	New: five levers with examples
Negotiation: positions vs interests	6.6	Extended: a worked sales-vs-product example
Five conflict modes and a five-step sequence	6.6	Extended: when to use each mode
Decision meeting anatomy	6.7	Extended: the timed agenda and the record
PRD sections	6.8	Extended: eight sections in order
Engineering scope negotiation dialogue	6.9	New: a worked dialogue and the four rules
Difficult stakeholder patterns	6.11	Extended: a response table
SBI feedback and the feedback loop	6.13	Extended: a worked SBI sentence
Executive reviews and bad news	6.14	New: five-sentence bad-news structure
Rewrite exercise with model answer	6.15	New: the rewrite with a model answer
Week 6 assignment	6.15	New: three-part brief

NOTE ON THE SOURCE

Some deck slides have labels only (for example, the layers of communication diagram). Only the labels are used here, and the text does not invent detail beyond them.

NEW · COMMUNICATION MAP

Communication follows the product stage

The deck's communication map links each stage of a product to its goal and to the documents that carry the message. Communicate more often and more formally as the stage gets closer to launch.

Stage	Goal of the stage	Typical documents and updates
Idea	Test the hypothesis	Research doc, progress notes, learnings
MVP	Test the hypothesis with a small group	PRD, project wiki, metrics updates
Early launch	Test product-market fit with a wider base	GTM plan, experiment plan, more updates
General availability	Plan to overcome the remaining obstacles	Launch review, support briefing, metrics against targets

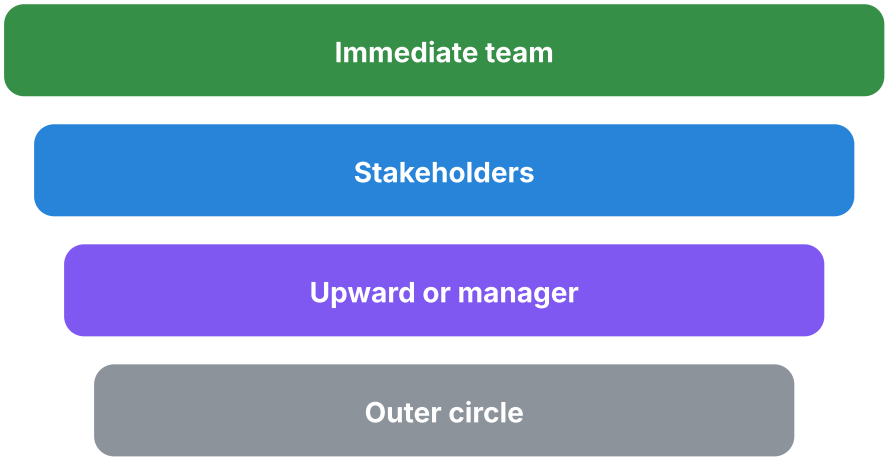
The deck's strategy: build and launch iteratively, so that each stage builds on what the last one proved.

NEW · LAYERS OF COMMUNICATION

Who hears what, and how often

The deck shows communication as layers around the PM. The labels are: **immediate team** (daily and weekly, the people who build), **stakeholders** (regular updates, the people who decide scope), **upward or manager level** (short, decision-focused updates), and the **outer circle** (occasional, outcome-focused updates for the wider company).

Match the level to the decision. A change to the team's sprint goes to the immediate layer. A change to launch timing goes up one layer and reaches the outer circle when it affects customers.



Layers of communication

EXTENDED · SECTION 6.2

Answer first: a worked checkout example

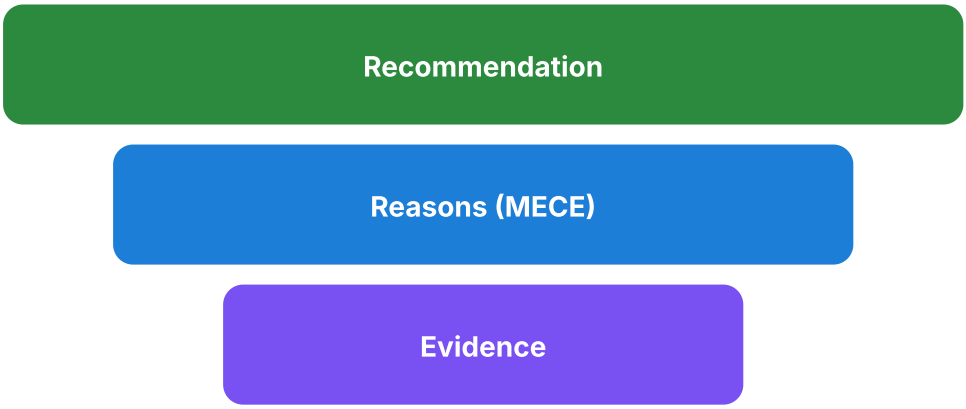
Lead with the governing thought, then group the reasons so that they do not overlap and leave no gap (the deck calls this MECE). Support each reason with evidence. A leader can stop reading at any level and still have the point.

Level	Content (hypothetical example)
Recommendation	Show the delivery fee in the cart this quarter.
Reason 1: biggest leak	30 percent leave at payment.
Reason 2: why it happens	6 of 8 users interviewed cite the fee surprise.
Reason 3: cheap and low risk	About two person-months; behind a feature flag.
Reason 4: we can prove it	A 14-day A/B test, with a guardrail: complaints at or below 1.3 percent.

SCQA: how to open any update, memo or pitch

Part	What it does	Example
Situation	Shared, uncontroversial context	Checkout is our main conversion step.
Complication	What changed or what is wrong	Payment drop-off has risen.
Question	The question the complication raises	What would reduce the drop-off fastest?
Answer	Your recommendation, then the reasons	Show the fee in the cart and test it.

Use SCQA when the audience needs context first. Use the pyramid when they need the answer first.



The pyramid: answer first, then reasons, then evidence

EXTENDED · SECTION 6.3

Storytelling with data

Make the title the takeaway, not the chart's name: 'Checkout loses most users at payment' is better than 'Funnel Q1'. Choose the chart by the question: a trend uses a line, a comparison uses bars, and a distribution uses a histogram. Remove clutter, and highlight one thing with colour.

EXTENDED · SECTION 6.5

RACI and DACI: a worked decision

RACI assigns work: **Responsible** does it, **Accountable** owns the outcome (one person), **Consulted** gives two-way input, and **Informed** is kept updated. DACI assigns a decision: the **Driver** runs the process, the **Approver** decides (one person), **Contributors** give input, and the **Informed** hear the result.

DACI role	Who (hypothetical example)
Driver	PM, checkout
Approver	Head of Product
Contributors	Design, engineering lead, analytics, payments, legal
Informed	Support, marketing, sales

Write the approver down before the debate starts. One approver per decision prevents most escalations.

NEW · INFLUENCE WITHOUT AUTHORITY

Five levers that work

Lever	What it looks like
Shared goals	'We both want fewer failed payments.' Start from the goal you share.
Evidence	Data, research and customer quotes beat opinions.
Reciprocity	Help others hit their goals too.
Early involvement	People defend what they helped write.
Follow-through	Do what you said. Credibility builds over time.

The deck adds one more: an **easy yes**, meaning a clear ask and a small first step.

EXTENDED · SECTION 6.6

Positions versus interests

A position is what someone asks for. An interest is why they ask. Solve for interests, and the positions often change.

Party	Position (what they ask for)	Interest (why)
Sales	Build custom reports for one client by June.	Keep a large renewal; the client's finance team needs monthly numbers.
Product	Not this quarter; checkout comes first.	Hit the checkout goal; avoid one-off custom features.

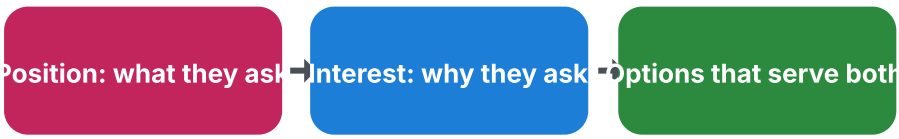
Options that serve both: a scheduled CSV export within two weeks, and a decision on custom reports in Q3, based on evidence from other clients.

The deck draws on Fisher and Ury's *Getting to Yes*: separate people from the problem, focus on interests, invent options, use objective criteria, and know your BATNA (your best alternative if no deal is reached).

Five conflict modes and a five-step sequence

Mode	Use it when
Collaborating	The issue is important and trust is high.
Compromising	The trade-off is time-bound.
Accommodating	The stakes are low and goodwill matters.
Competing	The call is urgent and clear-cut.
Avoiding	The issue is trivial.

1. Restate each side's interest until both agree you understood it.
2. Agree the shared goal and the decision criteria.
3. Lay out options with evidence.
4. Decide, or escalate together with a joint summary.
5. Document the decision and move on.



Solve for interests, not positions

NEW · ENGINEERING COLLABORATION

Negotiating scope with an engineering lead

The deck gives an illustrative dialogue. The PM starts from the goal, not the solution, then trades scope rather than quality.

Speaker	What they say
PM	Our goal is to stop the fee surprise for first-time buyers this quarter. What is the simplest version you would build?
Engineering lead	A static fee is easy. A live estimate needs the pricing service: three weeks, and it is unreliable at peak.
PM	What if v1 shows the estimate when the service replies within 500 ms, and 'estimate unavailable' otherwise?
Engineering lead	Then it is about ten days. We would add a cache later.
PM	Let's take that, behind a flag, as an A/B test. I will update the PRD and log the cache as a follow-up.

- Start with the goal, then ask for the simplest option.
- Ask for estimates as ranges with assumptions.
- Trade scope, not quality.
- Record the follow-up so it is not lost.
- Story points are planning tools, not productivity scores.

EXTENDED · SECTION 6.11

Difficult stakeholders: patterns and responses

Pattern	Response
The HiPPO (highest paid person's opinion)	Ask for the goal behind the idea; propose a test; show data respectfully.
The bulldozer ('just build it')	Acknowledge the urgency; show the cost of delay to displaced work; offer a smaller slice.
The silent blocker	Hold a one-to-one; ask what would make them comfortable; involve them early.
The scope-creeper	Point to the agreed scope and the decision log; queue new asks for the next cycle.
The customer-promiser	Agree a rule: no commitments without PM sign-off. Share themes, not dates.

EXTENDED · SECTION 6.7

Anatomy of a decision meeting

Stage	Time	What happens
Pre-read	48 hours before	A one-page brief: context, options and a recommendation
Frame	5 minutes	State the decision, the decider and the criteria
Options	15 minutes	Trade-offs and evidence for each option
Dissent	10 minutes	Ask 'what would make this wrong?'
Decide	5 minutes	Decide, or name the missing information
Record	24 hours after	Write the decision, rationale, owner and review date

Most of the work happens before and after the meeting. If nobody read the pre-read, read it together for the first five minutes.



Anatomy of a decision meeting

EXTENDED · SECTION 6.8

The PRD: eight sections in order

No.	Section	What to include
1	Summary and decision	Problem, proposal, impact, owner and status
2	Problem and evidence	Who, what task, why it is hard, data and quotes
3	Goals and metrics	Primary metric and target; guardrails
4	Users and use cases	Segments, key scenarios and edge cases
5	Scope	In and out of scope; assumptions
6	Requirements	User stories, acceptance criteria and non-functional needs
7	Design and analytics	Prototype links and a tracking plan
8	Launch and risks	Rollout, feature flags, rollback and open questions

WATCH OUT

Use AI for a first draft, never as the source of truth. Check every number, assumption and privacy detail before you share it.

User stories follow the form 'As a first-time buyer, I want to see my estimated total in the cart, so that I can decide before I start paying.' The deck's INVEST checklist asks that a story is Independent, Negotiable, Valuable, Estimable, Small and Testable.

EXTENDED · SECTION 6.13

SBI feedback and the feedback loop

Use SBI: **Situation**, **Behaviour**, **Impact**. For example: 'In yesterday's review (situation), the PRD's success metric changed from completion to clicks without a note (behaviour). Engineering built toward the old target, and two days were lost (impact).'

1. **Context:** be specific.
2. **Response:** listen fully.
3. **Action:** agree the next step.
4. **Close the loop:** confirm the outcome.

NEW · SECTION 6.14

Executive reviews and bad news

Executives want the decision you need, how it serves the strategy, metrics against targets with an honest green, amber or red, what you learned, and what you are not doing. Prepare answers to the three hardest questions first.

Bad news in five sentences

1. What happened, plainly.
2. The impact.
3. The cause, if known.
4. What you are doing, and what you need.
5. When you will update next.

EXAMPLE (HYPOTHETICAL)

'The launch will slip two weeks. A payment-gateway certification took longer than estimated. There is no customer-facing risk. I recommend waiting rather than launching without the new payment method. I will update you every Friday.'

NEW · EXERCISE

Rewrite this update

Original: 'We did lots of analysis this week. We looked at funnels, did interviews, talked to payments, and engineering thinks it's 2 months. Fees might be a problem. Also loyalty is pending.'

Rewrite it with the pyramid: the answer first, then two or three reasons with evidence, then the ask. Give yourself five minutes.

MODEL ANSWER (HYPOTHETICAL)

Recommendation: test showing the delivery fee in the cart from the next sprint. **Why:** (1) 30 percent of checkout starters leave at payment; (2) 6 of 8 interviewees cite the fee surprise; (3) a simplified v1 takes about two weeks, and the full live estimate about two months. **Ask:** approve the two-week v1 and an A/B test; move loyalty to Q3.

ASSIGNMENT

Week 6 assignment: three parts

1. **Executive summary:** write a one-screen summary for a product change you would recommend, in any app you use.
2. **Stakeholder map:** place six stakeholders on a power–interest grid, and write one action for each.
3. **Acceptance criteria:** write three Given/When/Then criteria for 'saved addresses'.

SELF-CHECK

Is the answer first? Does each reason come with evidence? Is every stakeholder's action specific? Does each criterion test one behaviour?

Quiz with answers

1. What does the pyramid principle ask you to put first?
   Answer: the governing thought or recommendation, then the supporting reasons.
2. In DACI, who decides?
   Answer: the Approver, one person.
3. What is the difference between a position and an interest?
   Answer: a position is what someone asks for; an interest is why they ask.
4. Which conflict mode fits an urgent, clear-cut call?
   Answer: competing.
5. In SBI, what does the B stand for?
   Answer: Behaviour.
6. How many sentences does the bad-news structure use?
   Answer: five.

MODULE 6 · FINAL

Completion checklist

Completion checklist

Done	Item
☐	Read the coverage map and marked the new topics
☐	Built one pyramid recommendation for a product you use
☐	Mapped stakeholders with a power–interest grid
☐	Wrote a DACI for one decision
☐	Rewrote the update exercise
☐	Completed the three-part assignment
☐	Answered the quiz without notes

MODULE 6 · COMPLETE CLASS NOTES

Everything else from the class slides

Every point from the class slides that is not already explained earlier in this PDF, grouped by slide. Points already covered are not repeated.

Class · slide 1 SkillNavora

- SkillNavora AI-FIRST PRODUCT MANAGEMENT · WEEK 6 Effective Communication as a Product Manager Lead without authority: structure your thinking, align every stakeholder, negotiate trade-offs and write documents people act on.
- Varun Kumar Founder & lead instructor, SkillNavora

Class · slide 2 TO DAY

- TO DAY What we'll cover 01 Communication is the job 02 A framework: audience, objective, approach 03 The three directions: team, upward, outer circle 04 Key documents and templates 05 Answer first: Pyramid, SCQA, BLUF, exec summaries 06 Storytelling: STAR, PREP and data 07 Stakeholder maps, RACI and DACI 08 Working with every function 09 Negotiation, conflict and difficult stakeholders 10 Meetings, PRDs and user stories 11 Feedback, exec reviews and bad news 12 AI for PM communication 13 Case study, assignment and interview prep SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 2

Class · slide 3 B E F O R E W E S TA R T

- B E F O R E W E S TA R T How this class works Ask anything If a question blocks you, ask right away.
- Otherwise park it for the Q&A at the end.
- Focus on the message Don't worry about every term.
- Slides and templates will be in your LMS after class.
- Be honest Share real examples and real feedback.
- The anonymous class survey helps us improve.
- Practise live We'll rewrite updates, map stakeholders and run a mock interview together.
- Bring your work Use a product you know (your job or your favourite app) for every exercise.
- Have fun Good communicators are curious and generous.

Class · slide 4 01

- 01 PA R T 1 Communication is the job Why the best PMs win on clarity, not on process.

Class · slide 5

F O U N DAT I O N S

- F O U N DAT I O N S Why communication is the PM's core tool PMs rarely have formal authority over the people who build, sell or support the product.
- Influence comes from clarity, evidence, trust and consistency.
- Most PM failures are communication failures: an unclear problem, an unshared trade-off, a surprise, or a decision nobody wrote down.
- Start with the answer, then support it Know your audience: what decision do they need to make?
- Make trade-offs explicit: options, cost, benefit, risk Label facts, assumptions and opinions Write it down: decisions, owners, dates No surprises: share bad news early, with a plan Listen more than you talk SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 5

Class · slide 6

M I N D S E T

- M I N D S E T Two habits of great communicators HABIT 1 Extreme ownership If the team misunderstood, the message wasn't clear enough.
- Own the outcome of every update: did the right people understand and act?
- Follow up until they do.
- Ask after every important message: "Who needed to act, and did they?" HABIT 2 Audience empathy Start from what the listener cares about, the words they use and the decision they face.
- An engineer, a CFO and a support lead need different versions of the same news.
- Rewrite the first line for each audience before you send.
- Rituals, trackers and templates matter less than the substance: the problem, the evidence, the decision and the trade-off.
- Fix the content first; the process is a vehicle.

Class · slide 7

A S Y S T E M

- A S Y S T E M Communication is a product system Design every update the way you design a feature: for a user, with a goal, through the right channel, with a way to learn if it worked.
- Audience Who needs to act?
- Message What must be clear?
- Channel Where will it travel?

Class · slide 8

AC R O S S T H E L I F E C YC L E

- AC R O S S T H E L I F E C YC L E What to communicate at each stage of a product Stage Goal Key artefacts Main audience Idea Is this worth exploring?
- One-pager, opportunity sizing Manager, design, tech lead Discovery Understand the problem User and market research doc Core team, leadership Definition Agree what to build PRD, designs, estimates Engineering, design, data MVP Test the riskiest hypothesis Experiment plan, progress updates, metrics Core team, manager Early launch Prove value with more users Project wiki, launch update, support FAQ Partners, ops, support General availability Scale and win Go-to-market plan, release notes, exec review Marketing, sales, leadership Growth Keep improving Experiment readouts, quarterly review Leadership, whole company Each stage has a different question, so the documents and the audience change.
- Reuse: the one-pager becomes the PRD summary; the PRD becomes the launch FAQ.

Class · slide 9

02

- 02 PA R T 2 A framework for every message Audience × objective × approach.

Class · slide 10

F R A M E WO R K

- F R A M E WO R K Audience, objective, approach 1 · Audience Core team (eng, design, data) Dependency teams Your manager and leadership Outer circle: ops, legal, support, marketing, sales Users and customers 2 · Objective Educate: share context Learn: get input or data Influence: change a view Decide: get a decision 3 · Approach Content: what to say, in what order Channel: doc, meeting, chat, demo Cadence: one-off, weekly, per release Before any update, write one line: "I want [audience] to [objective], so I'll [approach]." Example: "I want the Head of Payments to decide on the fee test, so I'll send a one-page brief 48 hours before Thursday's review." SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 10

Class · slide 11

C H A N N E L S

- C H A N N E L S Pick the channel by purpose and urgency Channel Best for Avoid for Document (PRD, memo, wiki) Complex reasoning, decisions, a record Quick questions Meeting Debate, alignment, sensitive topics Status that could be written Chat (Slack, Teams) Quick questions, coordination Decisions, long debates, bad news Async video (Loom) Demos, walkthroughs across time zones Anything that needs discussion Dashboard Metrics people check themselves Explaining why something changed Email / newsletter Wide updates, external partners Fast back-and-forth A useful rule: decisions in documents, discussion in meetings, coordination in chat.
- Then link the chat thread to the doc.

Class · slide 12

03

- 03 PA R T 3 The three directions Your core team, upward to leadership, and the outer circle.

Class · slide 13

T H R E E D I R E C T I O N S

- T H R E E D I R E C T I O N S Who you communicate with, and what they need Direction Who What they need Immediate (core team) Engineers, EMs, designers, analysts, data scientists Goal, problem, scope, details, decisions Upward Manager, skip-level, executives, counterpart managers Progress, risks, decisions needed, asks Outer circle Ops, legal, support, marketing, sales, finance, partners Context early, their impact, timelines SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 13

Class · slide 14

D I R E C T I O N 1

- D I R E C T I O N 1 The immediate team: who, what and how Who Engineering manager and engineers Design manager and designers Analysts and data scientists QA and tech writers What Alignment on goal, problem and solution Solution design details Roadmap and effort estimates Sprint ceremonies: stand-ups, reviews, retros Data, research and insights How Working sessions (not status meetings) Docs, wikis, boards, dashboards Chat for quick questions Demos of work in progress SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 14

Class · slide 15

DIRECTION1

- D I R E C T I O N 1 Best practices with your core team Involve them early Share the why before the what.
- Engineers and designers often see the simplest solution.
- Define responsibilities Who owns what (RACI) prevents confusion and finger-pointing later.
- Speak one language Shared terms, a shared board and one source of truth for decisions.
- Set shared goals Agree the outcome metric together so everyone pulls the same way.
- Protect focus Batch questions, keep scope stable mid- sprint, and say no on their behalf.
- Celebrate and credit Share wins with names in public updates.

Class · slide 16

DIRECTION2

- D I R E C T I O N 2 Communicating upward Who Your manager and skip-level Executives and business leaders Managers of partner teams What they want Progress against goals, in numbers Risks early, with your plan Decisions they need to make, and by when Your judgement: recommendations, not lists 1:1 notes doc · [You] / [Manager] Since last time Progress, wins, misses (looking back) Coming up Priorities for the next 2 weeks; align or adjust (looking forward) Help needed Decisions, blockers, introductions Workload How busy you are, so priorities stay realistic Manager's items What they want to discuss Growth (monthly) Career goals, feedback, skills to build Keep one running doc, newest on top.
- It becomes the record for reviews and promotions.

Class · slide 17

DIRECTION2

- D I R E C T I O N 2 The critical-issue update 🔴 Issue update · Payment failures · Update #2 · 14:00 IST Status Ongoing · Severity 1 Impact ~8% of payments failing since 11:20; ~1,900 users affected Cause Gateway timeout after config change (confirmed) Actions Rolled back config at 13:40; failures dropping; retry banner live Next steps Monitor 2h; post-mortem Thursday Next update 16:00 IST, or sooner if anything changes Owner PM: Asha · Eng: Rohit Send the first update fast, even if incomplete Same structure every time, so readers can scan Facts, then actions, then the next update time One owner; a single thread or channel Close it out: final update plus post-mortem link Hypothetical example.

Class · slide 18

DIRECTION3

- D I R E C T I O N 3 The outer circle Best practices with non-technical partners Set context early, with a short pre-read Repeat your goal, roadmap and progress, again and again Speak their language: impact on their team, not tech details Know their why, and share yours Be transparent about risks and dates Listen more than you talk SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 18

Class · slide 19

D I R E C T I O N 3

- D I R E C T I O N 3 A conversation with operations PM: We're launching 15-minute grocery delivery in Pune next month.
- I'd like your view on what would make it work for your team.
- Head of Ops: Honestly, our dark stores can't handle evening peaks yet.
- PM: That's exactly what I need to know.
- If we launch in two pin codes first, with orders capped at 6-9 pm, could the stores keep up?
- Head of Ops: Two pin codes, yes.
- I'd need 6 more pickers and a week of training.
- PM: Let's put that in the launch plan.
- I'll share the forecast by Friday so you can hire, and we'll review peak-hour data together every week.
- Start from their constraint, not your plan Offer a smaller, safer first step Turn their needs into launch requirements Agree a shared review rhythm Illustrative, fictional scenario.

Class · slide 20

D I R E C T I O N 3

- D I R E C T I O N 3 What each outer-circle partner cares about Partner Key considerations Operations Operational impact, resourcing and staffing, risk, metrics, timelines Legal & compliance Regulation, data privacy and consent, claims in copy, contracts, IP Customer support User issues, training and help articles, changes to the product, feedback loop, success metrics Product marketing Positioning, unique selling points, segments, competitors, launch strategy, key metrics Sales Roadmap themes, deal blockers, honest timelines, what not to promise Finance Cost, revenue impact, pricing, budget timing SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 20

Class · slide 21

04

- 04 PA R T 4 Key documents and templates The artefacts that keep everyone aligned.

Class · slide 22

D O C U M E N T S

- D O C U M E N T S Key documents by audience Document Purpose Primary audience Cadence PRD Problem, goals, scope, requirements Core team Per initiative; living Jira / tracker Work items, status, ownership Core team Daily Project wiki Single source of truth for the project Core team, leaders Updated continuously Progress update Status vs plan, risks, asks Team, partners, managers Weekly Launch update What shipped, for whom, how to measure Partners, leadership, support Per launch 1:1 notes doc Priorities, help, growth Your manager Each 1:1 Critical-issue update Impact, actions, next update Partners, managers, leaders During incidents SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 22

Class · slide 23 **T E M P L AT E**

- T E M P L AT E The project wiki: one source of truth Project wiki · Early fee display Summary One paragraph: problem, goal, status Team & roles PM, EM, design, data; DACI for decisions Goals & metrics Primary metric, target, guardrails; dashboard link Timeline Milestones and dates; current stage Links PRD, designs, Jira epic, experiment plan Decision log Date · decision · who · why Risks & open questions Owner and due date for each Updates Newest weekly update on top Audience: the working group plus relevant leaders Link out instead of copying, so nothing goes stale Anyone joining should get up to speed in 10 minutes Review it in every weekly sync SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 23

Class · slide 24 **T E M P L AT E**

- T E M P L AT E The weekly progress update Weekly update · Early fee display · Week of 12 May Overall 🟡 Amber: on track for the test, launch at risk by 1 week Progress Design done; 70% of build done; analytics events defined Metrics Not live yet; dashboard ready Risks Fee service latency at peak → fallback text agreed Decisions needed Legal wording for 'estimate' by Wednesday (owner: Legal) Next week QA, internal dogfood, experiment set-up Asks 1 QA engineer for 3 days Lead with an honest red/amber/green status and why Show change since last week, not a full history Every risk gets an owner and a date Make asks specific: who, what, by when Hypothetical example.

Class · slide 25 **T E M P L AT E**

- T E M P L AT E The launch update 🚀 Launched · Early fee display (A/B test) What Cart now shows estimated total incl. fees, for 50% of users Why 30% of checkout starters left at payment; fee surprise was the top reason Who it affects First-time and returning buyers on Android and iOS How we'll measure Checkout completion (+2 pts target); complaint- rate guardrail Support Help article and 3 macros; tag: fee_estimate Thanks Design: Meera · Eng: Rohit, Sana · Data: Kabir Next Readout on 30 May; decision on full rollout Send to partners, managers and support on launch day Explain the user value in one line Tell support exactly how to handle questions Credit the team by name SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 25

Class · slide 26 **05**

- 05 PA R T 5 Answer first Structures that make your point land in seconds.

Class · slide 27 **S T R U C T U R E**

- S T R U C T U R E The Pyramid Principle: answer first Recommendation: show the delivery fee in the cart this quarter Biggest checkout leak 30% leave at payment 6 of 8 users cite fee surprise Cheap and low-risk ~2 person-months Behind a feature flag We can prove it A/B test, 14 days Guardrail: complaints ≤ 1.3% Lead with the governing thought, group reasons (MECE: no overlaps, no gaps), support each with evidence.

Class · slide 28

S T R U C T U R E

- S T R U C T U R E SCQA: how to open any update, memo or pitch Situation Shared, uncontroversial context Complication What changed or what's wrong Question The question this raises Answer Your recommendation, then the pyramid Example.
- S: Checkout completion is 70% and our biggest growth lever this quarter.
- C: 30% leave at payment, and users say the fee surprises them.
- Q: What should we change first?
- A: Show the full fee in the cart, tested as a two-week A/B experiment.

Class · slide 29

W R I T I N G

- W R I T I N G BLUF and writing for busy readers BLUF: bottom line up front Put the conclusion or the ask in the first line, so a reader who stops there still knows what to do.
- Subject: Decision needed by Thu: approve 2-week fee test BLUF: I recommend we test early fee display for 2 weeks.
- I need your approval by Thursday.
- Writing checklist One idea per paragraph; short sentences Headings and bullets readers can scan Numbers with context (baseline, target, sample) Plain words; define any acronym once A clear ask with owner and date Your vision in one elevator-pitch line at the top of specs and decks SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 29

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W R I T I N G

- W R I T I N G The executive summary: one screen, top of every doc The ask: the decision and the date The recommendation Why: 2-3 bullets with numbers Risks and how you'll handle them What you need: people, money, decision What you're not doing Decision needed by 15 May: approve 2 engineers for 6 weeks to test early fee display.
- Recommendation: A/B test; ship only if completion rises ≥ 2 points with no rise in complaints.
- Why: payment step loses 30% of starters; 6/8 users cite fee surprise; est. +2,160 orders/month (range 720-4,320).
- Risks: estimate inaccuracy → label as estimate, fallback text.
- Not doing: loyalty redesign until Q3.

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W R I T I N G

- W R I T I N G Narrative memos and PR/FAQs NARRATIVE MEMO Think in full sentences Some companies (Amazon popularised it) replace slides with a written memo read silently at the start of the meeting.
- Prose forces complete reasoning: claims, evidence and trade-offs can't hide behind bullets.
- PR/FAQ Write the launch first Before building, write a one-page press release from the customer's point of view, then the FAQs customers and leaders would ask.
- If the press release isn't exciting, rethink the idea.

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S T R U C T U R E

- S T R U C T U R E Pick the structure by audience and purpose Situation Structure Shape Length Recommendation to leadership Pyramid + SCQA Answer → reasons → evidence 1 page / 3 min Behavioural interview story STAR Situation → Task → Action → Result 2 min Opinion in a meeting or stand-up PREP Point → Reason → Example → Point 30-60 s Feedback to a colleague SBI Situation → Behaviour → Impact → ask 2 min Bad news or incident 5 sentences What · impact · cause · plan · next update 1 message PREP in a stand-up.
- Point: delay the loyalty launch a week.
- Reason: payment errors tripled after Tuesday's release.
- Example: 412 failed attempts yesterday vs ~130 normally.
- Point: fix payments first, launch loyalty next Wednesday.

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06

- 06 PA R T 6 Storytelling STAR, data and the stories people remember.

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S TO RY T E L L I N G

- S TO RY T E L L I N G STAR turns activity into a story Without STAR "We shipped a feature and users liked it." With STAR "Week-2 retention had fallen to 31% (S) .
- I had to bring it back without new engineering headcount (T) .
- We interviewed 12 churned users, simplified onboarding from 5 steps to 3 and added a progress nudge (A) .
- Retention rose to 36% in six weeks, measured in an A/B test (R) ." Situation: context and the stakes, with a number Task: what you had to achieve, and the constraint Action: what you did (say "I", not only "we") Result: the measured outcome, or say it wasn't measured Add a one-line learning Use STAR in demos, leadership reviews and interviews.

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S TO RY T E L L I N G

- S TO RY T E L L I N G STAR in a team demo or leadership review "Our onboarding was losing 35% of new users at step 2 (S).
- We needed to improve activation without adding engineering scope (T).
- We rewrote two screens, tested two tooltip versions and removed one mandatory field (A).
- In two weeks activation rose 19% with only copy and configuration changes (R)." Data The number that shows the problem and the result.
- Emotion A user quote or moment that makes it real.
- Clarity One message the audience can repeat.
- Data + emotion + clarity = a story people remember and retell.

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DATA

- DATA Storytelling with data Title = takeaway: "Checkout loses most users at payment", not "Funnel Q1" Right chart: trend → line, comparison → bar, distribution → histogram Remove clutter; highlight one thing with colour Give context: baseline, target, sample size Show uncertainty: ranges, not false precision End with the action you want Checkout loses the most users at payment Cart → Checkout 30% Checkout → Address 8% Address → Payment 6% Payment → Order 30% Drop-off at each step.

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07

- 07 PA R T 7 Stakeholders and decision rights Map who matters and make it clear who decides.

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S TA K E H O L D E R S

- S TA K E H O L D E R S Map who matters: the power-interest grid High power, high interest: partner closely; bring options, not surprises High power, low interest: short, decision-focused updates Low power, high interest: keep informed; make progress easy to follow Re-map as the project changes; Legal can block a launch late if ignored Hypothetical placement for a checkout redesign.
- Keep satisfied Legal, Finance Manage closely VP Product, Head of Payments Monitor Partner restaurants Keep informed Support, Marketing Interest → Power → SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 38

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D E C I S I O N R I G H T S

- D E C I S I O N R I G H T S RACI and DACI: who decides?
- Writing this down before the debate prevents most escalations.
- Once decided, disagree and commit: everyone backs the decision, and the dissent is noted.

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I N F L U E N C E

- I N F L U E N C E Influence without authority: what actually works Shared goals "We both want fewer failed payments." Evidence Data, research and customer quotes beat opinions.
- Easy yes Clear asks and small first steps.

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C O L L A B O R AT I O N

- C O L L A B O R AT I O N Working with every function Partner They need from you You need from them Common friction Engineering Clear problem, stable scope, early involvement Estimates, risks, options Late changes; dates set without them Design Problem, evidence, time to explore Flows, prototypes, research Solution-first requests Data Decisions and tracking needs early Definitions, analysis, experiments Ad-hoc asks with no decision Marketing Positioning, dates, user value Messaging, launch plan Late notice; overpromising Sales Roadmap themes, honest timelines Customer feedback, deal blockers Promising features to close deals Support Release notes, known issues Ticket trends, pain points Launching without readiness Legal Early sight of data and claims Risk review, approvals Brought in at the last minute SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 41

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E N G I N E E R I N G

- E N G I N E E R I N G Negotiating scope with an engineering lead PM: Our goal is to stop the fee surprise for first-time buyers this quarter.
- What's the simplest version you'd build?
- Eng lead: Then it's about ten days.
- Goal first, not a solution Ask for the simplest option Estimates as ranges with assumptions Trade scope, not quality Record the follow-up Story points are team planning tools, not productivity scores Illustrative dialogue.

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08

- 08 PA R T 8 Negotiation and conflict Find the interests behind the positions.

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N E G OT I AT I O N

- N E G OT I AT I O N Positions vs interests Sales position "Build custom reports for Client X by June." Product position "Not this quarter, checkout comes first." Sales interest Keep a ₹40 lakh renewal; the client's finance team needs monthly numbers.
- Options that serve both Scheduled CSV export in 2 weeks now · custom reports evaluated in Q3 with evidence from other clients.

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C O N F L I C T

- C O N F L I C T Resolving conflict Five conflict modes (Thomas-Kilmann) Collaborating: important, high-trust issues Compromising: time-bound trade-offs Accommodating: low stakes, build goodwill Competing: urgent, clear-cut calls Avoiding: trivia only A five-step sequence
- Document and move on SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 45

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09

- 09 PA R T 9 Meetings and product documents Make meetings decide, and documents align.

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M E E T I N G S

- M E E T I N G S The types of communication a PM runs Format Purpose Make it work 1:1s Trust, priorities, growth Shared notes doc; the other person's agenda first Team syncs Coordination and blockers Agenda in advance; decisions and owners at the end Stand-ups Daily unblocking 15 minutes; problems taken offline Docs (PRDs, memos) Reasoning and decisions Summary on top; comments resolved Feature pitches Get buy-in for an idea SCQA opening; problem before solution Status updates Visibility RAG status, change since last time, asks Research synthesis Share what users told us Insights with evidence and quotes Design reviews Feedback on a solution Review against the problem and principles, not taste Leadership reviews Decisions and alignment Pre-read, decisions needed, hardest questions answered SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 48

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M E E T I N G S

- M E E T I N G S Anatomy of a decision meeting Pre-read (T−48h) 1-page brief: context, options, recommendation Frame · 5 min Decision, decider, criteria Options · 15 min Trade-offs and evidence Dissent · 10 min "What would make this wrong?" Decide · 5 min Or name the missing information Record (T+24h) Decision, rationale, owner, review date Share an agenda before every meeting and a summary with action items after it.

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D O C U M E N T S

- D O C U M E N T S User stories and acceptance criteria User story.
- INVEST checklist Independent · Negotiable · Valuable · Estimable · Small · Testable One-pager before a PRD Problem, why now, who, approach, impact range, cost, risks, the ask.
- If it doesn't fit on one page, the idea isn't clear yet.
- Acceptance criteria (Given / When / Then) Given an eligible address, when the cart opens, then show item price, estimated fees, taxes and total.
- Given the fee service fails, when the cart loads, then show "Estimate unavailable" and a Retry button, and never show an invented fee.
- Given the address changes, when the cart reloads, then refresh the estimate within 2 seconds (p95).

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10

- 10 PA R T 1 0 Feedback and leadership communication Keep the loop open; deliver bad news well.

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F E E D B AC K

- F E E D B AC K Feedback is a loop, not an event SBI: Situation · Behaviour · Impact "In yesterday's review (S), the PRD's success metric changed from completion to clicks without a note (B).
- Engineering built tracking for the old metric and lost a day (I).
- Could we add a change log to the PRD?" Receiving feedback: thank, clarify, don't defend in the moment, decide what to act on, close the loop. 1 · Context Be specific 2 · Response Listen fully 3 · Action Agree the next step 4 · Close Follow up SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 53

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CA D E N C E

- CA D E N C E Keep every audience informed Audience Format Cadence Contents Leadership One-page update Weekly / fortnightly Metrics vs target, decisions needed, risks Partners Channel post + sync Weekly Progress, blockers, upcoming asks Support & sales Release notes + FAQ Per release What changed, how to explain it, known issues Whole company Demo / newsletter Monthly Outcomes and learnings Anyone affected by an incident Incident message Now, then on a schedule Impact, plan, next update time SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 54

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L E A D E R S H I P

- L E A D E R S H I P Executive reviews and delivering bad news What executives want The decision you need How it serves the strategy Metrics vs targets, with honest green/amber/red Learnings: what surprised you, what you stopped What you're not doing Anticipate the three hardest questions Bad news in five sentences
- What you're doing, and what you need
- When you'll update next "The launch will slip two weeks.
- I'll update you every Friday." SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 55

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11

- 11 PA R T 1 1 AI for PM communication Faster drafts, better clarity, your judgement.

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A I

- A I Use AI to communicate better, not to think less Good uses Turn messy notes into a structured update Rewrite one message for three audiences Summarise research or long threads Find gaps: "What would an engineer ask?" Draft STAR stories from your notes Check tone before sending difficult messages Ground rules Never paste confidential or personal data into public tools Check every number, name and claim AI drafts; you decide and own the message Keep your own voice; edit generic phrasing Claude, ChatGPT and Gemini are all useful here.
- Use your company's approved tool for work data.

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A I P R O M P T S

- A I P R O M P T S Prompts you can use this week STAR story Turn these notes into a STAR story for a PM interview.
- Keep my actions specific, use only the numbers I give, and flag anything missing: [notes] Pyramid rewrite Rewrite this update using the Pyramid Principle: recommendation first, then 3 reasons with evidence, then the ask.
- Under 120 words: [update] Audience versions Write three versions of this launch note: for engineers (details), for leadership (impact and risks) and for support (what to tell customers): [note] Stress test Act as a sceptical CFO.
- List the 5 hardest questions you'd ask about this proposal and what evidence would convince you: [proposal] Meeting summary Summarise this meeting transcript into decisions, owners, dates and open questions.
- Do not invent anything: [transcript] SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 58

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12

- 12 PA R T 1 2 Practice, case study and interview prep Apply everything from today.

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P R AC T I C E

- P R AC T I C E Exercise: rewrite this update Original "We did lots of analysis this week.
- Also loyalty is pending." Your turn (5 minutes) Rewrite it with the Pyramid Principle: answer first, then 2-3 reasons with evidence, then the ask.

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CAS E S T U DY

- CAS E S T U DY Rising cancellations at a home-services app FixRight (a fictional home-services app for cleaning, plumbing and repairs) has seen booking cancellations rise from 9% to 15% over three months.
- The CEO wants a recommendation in Friday's leadership review.
- In groups (15 minutes)
- Map them on a power-interest grid
- Which data would you pull, and from whom?
- Write the SCQA opening for Friday's review
- Draft the one-page update: findings, options, recommendation, asks Hints Split cancellations by who cancels: customer or professional Look by category, city, time to job and price shown vs final Talk to support and ops: they hear the reasons first Separate facts, assumptions and next experiments End with a clear ask and the next update date SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 61

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T H I S W E E K

- T H I S W E E K Assignment
- PRD: FitCircle, a fictional fitness app, wants streaks, rewards and friend challenges to improve 30-day retention.
- Write a PRD for design and engineering using the template in your LMS.
- Executive summary: one screen recommending the launch plan, for the CEO.
- Stakeholder map: six stakeholders on a power-interest grid, one action each.
- Launch update: the message you'd send on launch day.
- Submit in your LMS under Week
- Written feedback before next week's class.
- What good looks like Problem and evidence before features One primary metric plus guardrails (e.g. no rise in injuries or uninstalls) Clear scope: in, out, later Testable acceptance criteria Risks: fairness, cheating, notification fatigue SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 62

Class · slide 63 **I N T E RV I E W P R E P**

- I N T E RV I E W P R E P Communication questions PM interviewers ask Question What they're testing Answer outline Tell me about a time you influenced without authority Influence, evidence, empathy STAR; shared goal, data, options; real result Describe a conflict with engineering.
- How did you resolve it?
- Conflict handling, respect Both sides' interests; options; decision; relationship after How would you tell executives a launch is delayed?
- Bad news, ownership 5 sentences; options with a recommendation; next update How do you handle a stakeholder who keeps adding scope?
- Prioritisation, boundaries Goal, cost of delay, decision log, next cycle How do you keep a large cross-functional project aligned?
- Systems thinking Project wiki, weekly update, DACI, rituals Walk me through a PRD you wrote Clarity, structure Problem, evidence, metrics, scope, trade-offs, what you'd change Sales promised a feature to a client.
- What do you do?
- Judgement, partnership Understand the interest; options; shared rule for the future How do you explain a technical trade-off to a non-technical leader?
- Translation Impact first, analogy, options, recommendation SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 63

Class · slide 64 **I N T E RV I E W P R E P**

- I N T E RV I E W P R E P Model answer: "Describe a conflict with engineering" S: Two weeks before a launch, our tech lead wanted to delay by a sprint to fix performance; sales had already announced the date.
- T: I needed a decision that protected users without losing the launch.
- A: I met the tech lead 1:1 to understand the risk, which was slow load times for 20% of Android users.
- I asked for options: we found we could launch to iOS and high-end Android first and fix performance behind a flag.
- I wrote a one-page options note and took it to my manager and the sales lead together.
- R: We launched on time to 80% of users; the rest followed 9 days later with no complaints spike.
- Learning: bring options, not positions.
- Hypothetical model answer: use your own real story and numbers.
- Do Say "I" for your actions Show you understood the other side Give the measured result, or say it wasn't measured End with what you learned Don't Blame the other team Invent numbers Tell a story where you simply escalated SkillNavora · Week 6 · Effective Communication as a PM 64

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I N T E RV I E W P R E P

- I N T E RV I E W P R E P A 60-second story bank Prepare five stories before any PM interview.
- Each one can answer many questions.
- A decision you made with incomplete data
- A trade-off you negotiated
- A stakeholder conflict you resolved
- A launch or project that went wrong, and what you learned
- A result you are proud of, with numbers Practise Write each as STAR in under 150 words Say it aloud in 60-90 seconds Prepare follow-ups: "What would you do differently?" Practise with AI as the interviewer, then with a peer Book a mock interview in your LMS Interviewers often ask for one decision story, one trade-off, one conflict and one measurable result.

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S U M M A RY

- S U M M A RY Key takeaways Communication is the job Own the outcome of every message; start from your audience.
- Audience · objective · approach Pick content, channel and cadence on purpose.
- Answer first Pyramid, SCQA and BLUF; MECE reasons with evidence.
- Stories that stick STAR for stories, PREP for quick points, data with a takeaway title.
- Decision rights RACI/DACI, written decisions, disagree and commit.
- Interests over positions Negotiate with options and objective criteria.
- Living documents PRD, wiki, weekly and launch updates keep everyone aligned.

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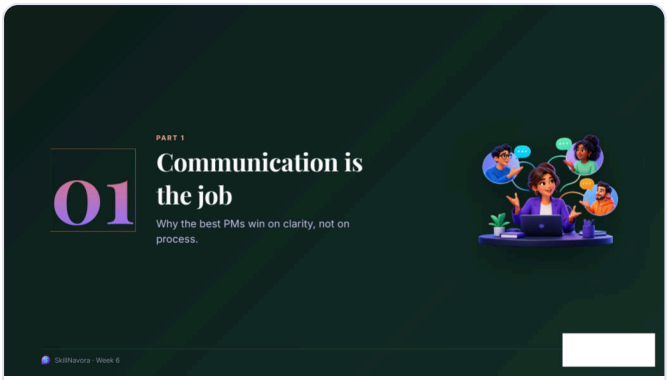
C H E AT S H E E T

- C H E AT S H E E T Before you hit send ☐ Who must act, and is it clear in the first line? ☐ Is the answer or ask up front (BLUF)? ☐ Are facts, assumptions and opinions labelled? ☐ Is every number in context? ☐ Is there an owner and a date for each ask? ☐ Is this the right channel? ☐ Would this surprise anyone?
- Questions? support@skillnavora.in · www.skillnavora.in Further reading: Barbara Minto, The Pyramid Principle · Cole Nussbaumer Knaflic, Storytelling with Data · Fisher, Ury & Patton, Getting to Yes · Atlassian DACI playbook · CCL SBI feedback model · Sachin Rekhi, Mastering effective communication as a PM.

MODULE 6 · SLIDE VISUALS

Visual slides from the class

These slides are mostly pictures and diagrams, so they are shown as images. Read them with the notes above.



Slide 4



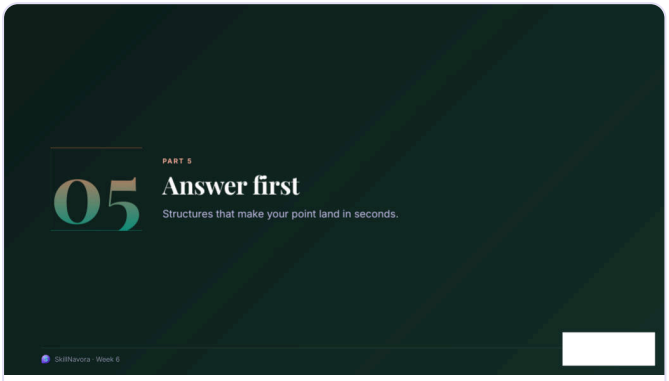
Slide 9



Slide 12



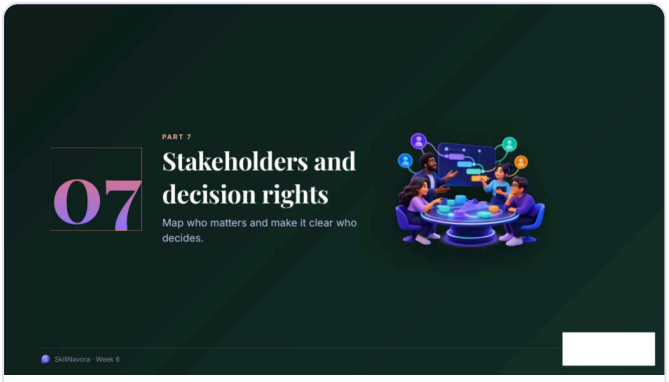
Slide 21



Slide 26



Slide 33



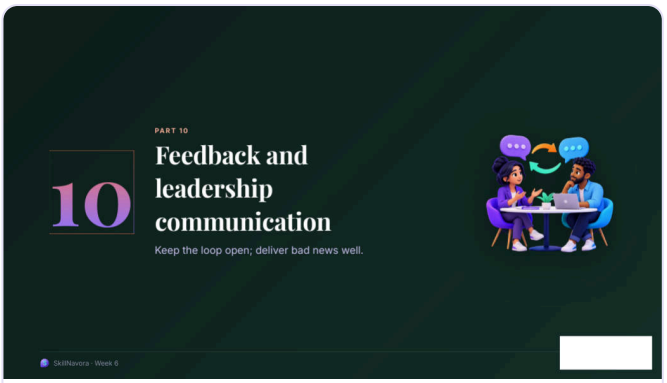
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